IN PURSUIT OF PERFECTION

ANANYA BIRLA, 27

Founder & Chairperson, Svatantra Microfin; Co-founder, Mpower Minds; Singer & Songwriter
Mumbai

Ananya Birla wears many hats. She is a singer, songwriter, entrepreneur and a mental health advocate. At 17, Ananya started Svatantra Microfin, which now has presence across 78,000 villages in 20 states, employs over 6,000 individuals and has impacted 18 million lives. It is the only microfinance institution to extend 100 per cent cashless disbursements since inception. Svatantra MHFC, the micro-housing arm, is among the few housing institutions to focus on the economically weaker sections. Svatantra Microfin's gross loan portfolio has grown at a compounded annual growth rate (CAGR) of 135 per cent from 2015 to 2022 and Svatantra MHFC's at a CAGR of 133 per cent (2017-2022). Ananya's Mpower Minds is an initiative to alleviate the stigma associated with mental health while the Ikai Asai venture empowers local artisans.

Daughter of industrialist Kumar Mangalam Birla and Neerja Birla, Ananya is an alumnus of Oxford University and founder of the Ananya Birla Foundation. In May 2020, the foundation made its first grant to Save the Children India, targeting 100,000 individuals. It is currently working on research and intervention designs in mental health in rural India. Ananya is also an ambassador of the National Alliance on Mental Illness.

As a singer, Ananya boasts of over 400 million streams globally. She is the only English language Indian artist to record platinum sales, a feat repeated five times over. The MTV Europe Music Awards nominee began her musical journey at the age of nine with the santoor. She fuses her drumming, piano and guitar skills into her live performances. ■

– M.G. Arun

THE MUSIC OF HER LIFE
Ananya will be releasing an English album and a Hindi-Punjabi one in 2022. Apart from playing the drums and santoor, she writes poems. Books are her other passion—she is currently reading *The People Code* by Taylor Hartman and *Tools of Titans* by Tim Ferriss

"Business or music, leaving a lasting impact on people's lives drives all my pursuits"